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Introduction

The conversation around PPC has shifted dramatically in such a short amount of time. A year ago, many advertisers were still treating AI as something on the horizon: a useful experiment, but not yet central to how campaigns were run.

Today, it's no longer a side project. AI is baked into nearly every part of the platforms we use, from campaign types like Performance Max and Demand Gen to the creative tools that write ad copy and generate images on demand.

That shift has opened up real opportunities. Campaigns can be launched faster, scaled across more channels, and fed with creative variations that would have taken entire teams to produce in the past.

At the same time, the ubiquitous presence of AI in PPC platforms has introduced new frustrations. Granular controls are harder to find. Legacy tactics don't always translate. And many marketers are still wrestling with how to measure success when so much of the process is hidden behind automation.

This year, we asked several leading PPC professionals to share their honest perspectives on what it means to build campaigns in an AI-first world.

We wanted to know:

- How are they actually using AI tools in their day-to-day work?
- Where do they still feel limited or constrained?
- What strategies are helping them succeed with Performance Max, Demand Gen, and other automation-heavy formats?
- How are they approaching durable measurement when attribution is murkier than ever?
- How is generative AI changing their approach to ad copy and creative testing?

In each section, you'll find responses from:

Navah Hopkins
Product Liaison, Microsoft

Gil Gildner
Agency Co-Founder, Discosloth

Jyll Saskin Gales
Google Ads Coach, Inside Google Ads

Jonathan Kagan
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Mike Ryan
Head of Ecommerce Insights, Smarter Ecommerce

Brooke Osmundson
Director of Growth Marketing, Smith Micro Software, Inc.

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Senior Manager, Organic Growth
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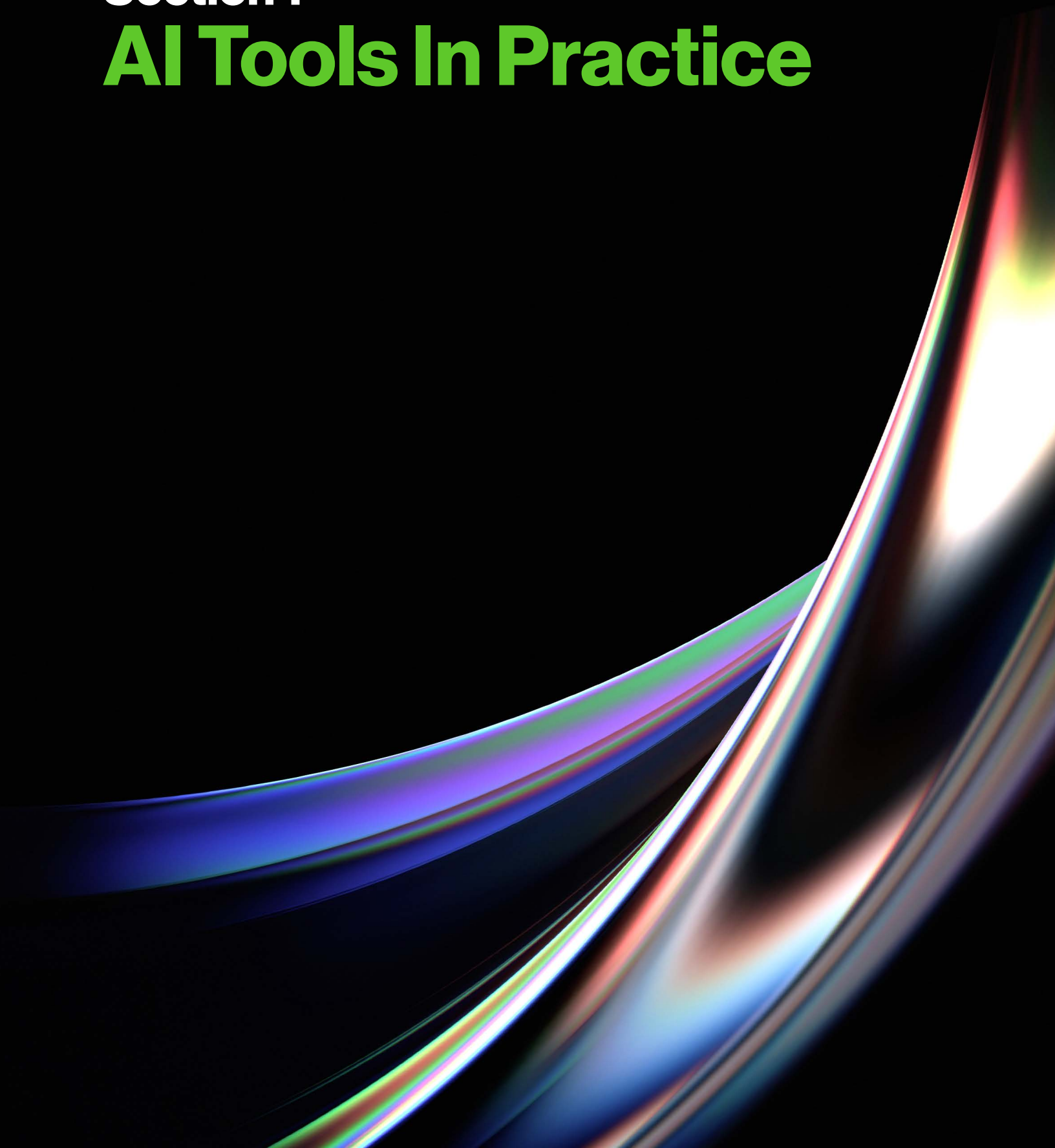
Their answers reflect an industry in transition. Some see AI as a time-saver and creative partner. Others are skeptical of the trade-offs in transparency and control.

What's clear is that PPC professionals are no longer asking whether AI belongs in their toolbox. The real question is how to use it wisely, without losing the expertise and critical thinking that make campaigns succeed.

As you read through the insights that follow, you'll see points of consensus on what's working and plenty of debate on what still needs solving. That mix of agreement and tension reflects where the industry stands right now: adapting quickly, experimenting constantly, and learning in real time what it means to manage campaigns in an era shaped by AI.

Section 1

AI Tools In Practice



Brooke Osmundson Director of Growth Marketing, Smith Micro Software, Inc.

This wouldn't be a proper ebook without starting out with everyone's favorite subject, AI tools.

AI tools have quickly shifted from being "nice-to-have" experiments to everyday necessities in PPC workflows. For some, this means leaning into what platforms already provide: automatically generated headlines, images, and targeting recommendations. For others, it extends outside of the platforms into third-party tools that analyze performance data, surface audience insights, or even generate competitor research on demand.

The promise of AI is **speed and scale**. Campaigns can be launched faster, reporting can be streamlined, and creative testing can move from weeks to hours. While AI can churn out ideas, it rarely provides the strategic context that determines whether those ideas actually matter.

This is the reality for many advertisers: AI tools are already saving time, but success still requires human oversight, quality control, and critical thinking. Marketers who get results are the ones blending automation with expertise, letting AI handle repetitive tasks while reserving judgment and strategy for themselves.

The first prompt I asked contributors to respond to was:

> **"How are you actually using AI tools (inside or outside ad platforms) to make campaigns more effective, and what limitations have you encountered? How can readers find success in using AI tools?"**

Navah Hopkins Product Liaison, Microsoft

Currently, my favorite AI tool to use is Microsoft's Copilot's tone assist for ad copy. Beyond being a great resource to adapt text and visual content to different stages in the buying journey, it helps adjust language based on given prompts and tones.

This allows you to easily pivot creative from the original copy to "warm" or "professional" with a click of a button. This way, you can easily create ads targeted towards decision makers as well as the end user of the product or service.

For advertisers, this means it's much easier to iterate and test creative, while staying true to core messaging and brand authenticity. This is key for advertisers who are looking for more creative assistance, but need to get creative pre-approved before launching.

AI also helps you capitalize on all the placements possible within an ad platform's inventory. By leaning into the formatting help, you ensure your ads will represent you to the best of their ability on the maximum number of surfaces.

Gil Gildner Agency Co-Founder, Discosloth

Although many marketers were understandably hesitant at first, the reality is that AI tools have become indispensable and very, very efficient.

We have fully integrated AI tools across our entire PPC stack, all the way from keyword research and ideating copy to generating display or text ads to, perhaps most importantly, analyzing large datasets and extracting unique performance trends.

The first few generations of LLMs were pretty crude, but the latest Gemini and Grok 4 models are pretty good. You've got to keep an eye on the output for accuracy, and it still definitely needs a lot of strategic shepherding, but I can now do things in minutes that used to require either hours of my time, or a full-time assistant. I've even used it to build small, single-use one-off web apps in a matter of minutes.

I only see the usefulness and accuracy of AI tools accelerating over the next few years, so I think marketers need to keep their finger on the pulse of these tools; otherwise, we'll all be left in the dust! There are a lot of unknowns with the future of AI, but the only thing certain is that we have to adapt. Change is inevitable.

Jyll Saskin Gales Google Ads Coach, Inside Google Ads

I am not currently making use of many external AI tools, though I anticipate that will change this year.

What I am currently leveraging is one of the core AI features that already exists in Google Ads, and we're likely all using it in some capacity: Smart Bidding.

Yes, this is a highly effective AI tool, and in 2026, you will be hard-pressed to convince me that you can drive better, sustainable, scalable results with manual bidding rather than properly configured Smart Bidding.

Jonathan Kagan Director of Search & Media Strategy, Amsive

This is often dependent on the definition of "AI tools." We have utilized platform bid optimization tools, which learn in an AI concept for years, which aid in day-to-day management.

However, under the newer concept of "AI," which often leans toward building creatives and campaign structures, it is a mixed bag. We have not found AI to be effective at building structures, because it does it in the platform's eye, not the advertisers.

As for the creative side, it often depends on the vertical we are currently working on. Text-based ads, we've utilized AI for actual ads in non-government-regulated verticals, and it often requires heavy editing to make it a compliant or even logical creative.

For government-regulated brands, where everything has to go through legal scrutiny, we will use the AI suggestions as thought starters to help us create an ad, but cannot typically use the actual output.

On the image or visual creative side, we find that AI makes a decent effort in creating ads with humans in "lifestyle" or "behavioral" actions, but for some reason, when it comes to visual creative that does not feature a human being, the imagery is often unusable. Conceptually, there is an opportunity to use them in the future for creatives, but it still requires more of a learning experience by the tool.

Mike Ryan **Head of Ecommerce Insights, Smarter Ecommerce**

AI permeates every layer of campaigns like Performance Max, from bidding and targeting to placements and creatives.

The main limitation that I see time and again is no fault of the technology: It only knows what it knows. It only knows the data in your feed, in the channels managed, in the audience graph. That's a lot, actually.

But, you can make it way smarter, and better aligned to your business, by telling it all the information that it simply doesn't know. This is your first-party data.

The next biggest limitation is our fault: It's a limit of imagination. Your first-party data is not just your remarketing lists! It can be your detailed stock levels, your sell-through rate, your margins, your competitor intel, your high-value audiences, your knowledge of other channels, like what's working on social media.

It can be anything at all that creates value, and which the algorithm doesn't know about. You can reflect this in custom labels, in signals, search themes, campaign structure, budget, or return on ad spend (ROAS) target. These are how you communicate with the AI tools.

Darrell Tyler Senior Manager, Organic Growth, CallRail

We are actively leveraging AI tools both within and outside ad platforms to enhance campaign effectiveness. A primary application involves identifying patterns and trends in campaign data, allowing us to analyze click-through rates (CTR) and determine which headlines and titles resonate most with our target audience. In addition, AI also helps us build comprehensive knowledge bases that deepen our understanding of audience needs and pinpoint gaps in our competitor strategies.

Beyond these analytical applications, practical AI use cases we use include in-platform bidding adjustments, and even training custom AI models, such as custom gems and GPTs, on our specific business data. By providing these models with campaign context and regularly ingesting performance data, we can effectively analyze campaign performance, brainstorm new opportunities, and rigorously test and produce ad copy.

A significant limitation we've encountered is the "garbage in, garbage out" theory. This highlights the importance of investing substantial time upfront to tailor AI tools to our unique business needs. Without this initial time investment in precise configuration and data input, achieving real, impactful results from AI tools becomes extremely challenging. Therefore, success depends on careful setup and continuous refinement to ensure the AI is working with relevant and high-quality information.

With that being said, we are also aware that AI models can pick up on and exhibit biases from the source data, the training process, or learning algorithm, or even the prompt or prompter. Finally, as we all likely know, it's always possible that AI can produce inaccurate, irrelevant, or nonsensical outputs, so it's crucial to closely review them.

Section 2

Maintaining Visibility & (Some) Control

Brooke Osmundson Director of Growth Marketing, Smith Micro Software, Inc.

The steady march toward campaign consolidation has left advertisers with fewer knobs to turn, and far more reliance on campaign types where automation is the main driver. Performance Max and Demand Gen are the clearest examples, but the trend is broader: less segmentation, less reporting detail, and more black-box decision-making by the platforms themselves.

For PPC professionals, that raises a pressing concern: How do you keep visibility into what's actually happening? Many advertisers still want to know which queries triggered ads, which creative assets are working, and which audiences are delivering conversions. Without that clarity, it's difficult to justify spend, explain results to stakeholders, or make meaningful optimizations.

The challenge, then, is balancing automation with accountability. It may mean learning how to read platform signals differently, leaning on supplemental data sources, or restructuring campaigns to align with what visibility still exists. While the path forward isn't simple, marketers can't afford to hand over complete control without building safeguards.

The next question I asked our PPC experts was:

> **"What advice would you give marketers to maintain visibility and control as Google continues to consolidate campaign types into AI-first formats?"**

Navah Hopkins Product Liaison, Microsoft

The important unspoken part in maintaining visibility and control is within your conversion data. Conversions are the fuel needed to teach AI who are the most valuable people to you, as well as what they can cost while still being profitable.

Especially in smaller accounts, there's a valid reason to consolidate conversions, and that's to ensure there's enough data to help the algorithm understand what's driving the most value. If conversion data isn't shared, it's impossible for the ad platform's AI to correctly understand where to put your budget, how to communicate with your customers, and when to engage in those conversations.

This is true for both Google and Microsoft. In Microsoft Ads, it allows even more ad group-level settings. This means you need less budget to cover more markets.

The ideal state is to have consent mode conversions set up along with offline conversions to ensure the most accurate data is passed through. However, if you can't rely on conversions, you may need to lean into tools like impression-based remarketing, which don't require as rigorous consent to build targeting/excluding audiences.

Gil Gildner Agency Co-Founder, Discosloth

Google is integrating Gemini (and unique Google Ads-specific models) fairly rapidly into the ads platform. For the first few years, at Discosloth, we weren't 100% sold on the implementation of AI, and it's still far from perfect.

However, it's nearing the inflection point, and I think it's getting good enough that there will be a major switch soon. I'm still not totally sold on AI Max, but it's still in its infancy.

By now, Performance Max is pretty much a given. The ad generation isn't bad, but it still needs a lot of personalized editing.

Personally, I've found the chat sidebar within Google Ads to not be useful, but what a lot of advertisers don't like to admit is that it is oriented towards a beginner or novice market (small business advertisers, freelancers, or folks who can't afford a large agency on retainer).

It will only continue to improve, and continue to block out the whole small business market from agencies. It's not necessarily a bad thing; it's just something for every PPC specialist to keep in mind for the foreseeable future. It is absolutely critical to go upmarket because I believe AI-first campaigns are going to fully take over the smallest accounts.

Jyll Saskin Gales Google Ads Coach, Inside Google Ads

While it's true that advertisers have less transparency and less control now than we used to, I think it's time for a reframing of what visibility and control actually mean.

Can you still control your exact search terms, your exact bids, your exact ad creatives? No. It's not possible with AI-first formats like PMax and AI Max. But that doesn't mean you have no control; it means your levers for control are changing.

Rather than setting strict parameters for campaigns to follow, and using whack-a-mole tactics to force them into submission (like negative keywords or manual bid adjustments), the new control is setting a clear destination for campaigns to follow, and providing sufficient data, budget, and flexibility to let your campaigns get there.

For example, providing compelling ad creative, using full-funnel conversion tracking, and having a well-optimized website – these are all things you can and should control, and are just a few of the many controls you still have in an AI-first world.

It's like giving your teenager a Mapquest printout of directions to follow, vs. giving them the address and trusting that they can figure out how to get there, even if they make a few wrong turns along the way.

Jonathan Kagan **Director of Search & Media Strategy, Amsive**

Google mentioned to us over the years, via account reps and even at previous Google Marketing Live events, that its future will be keywordless and AI-led, so this has been something we have been preparing for, for quite some time.

While Google and other platforms continue to push forward with AI at the forefront, we have realized that the most important thing is to not forget the basics and best-in-class standard operating procedures.

There is a high-level need to not dismiss all suggestions and recommendations from Google immediately, but to test them and/or question them. Both of these lead to scrutiny of the effort, but it also means you may not miss out on a good opportunity.

As an industry, we've pushed back substantially on Performance Max, one of the biggest AI-first functions Google offers, and with that, pushing back came several changes, enhancements, and ultimately improved controls of the ad unit itself.

Change toward Google's AI-first mentality is largely inevitable, but that does not mean it can be allowed to happen without question. We have discovered frequently that AI-first is not perfect (and far from it), and without feedback and a degree of pushback, it will not improve.

Our control in the AI-first era of Google is to be the ones that help guide Google on how to make it truly work properly, and insisting transparency comes with it.

Mike Ryan **Head of Ecommerce Insights, Smarter Ecommerce**

Fortunately for us marketers, this question isn't as hard as it was a year ago. It's true that we have a very large dependence on ad platforms to furnish us with data for making decisions, plus features for taking action. But, that's exactly the direction Google has gone lately.

They've revived search term reports and negative keywords for PMax, added brand controls, device controls, and demographic exclusions. Meanwhile, Demand Gen has fully-fledged channel reporting and channel targeting. And AI Max is highly customizable with good levels of transparency.

I actually think that the worst days of "blackboxing" are behind us, and we've arrived at a mature level where AI campaigns are more mutually beneficial than ever.

The tricky part is not to get in our own way: excluding traffic can turn into death by optimization; campaign segmentation needs to consider conversion volumes; channels may play an important role that isn't recognizable at face value.

The goal is to keep campaigns on track, not micromanage them.

Darrell Tyler **Senior Manager, Organic Growth, CallRail**

As Google continues to consolidate campaign types into AI-first formats, marketers should prioritize establishing clear baselines now. These AI-first formats are still evolving rapidly, and somewhat of a guessing game. Understanding their impact requires careful measurement as changes continue to occur.

By setting up controlled tests comparing these new AI-driven formats against traditional approaches, marketers can gain valuable insights into what performs best for their specific goals. This proactive approach allows for data-driven adjustments and optimization.

While the technology behind these formats is becoming increasingly automated, user behavior remains a critical factor in campaign success. Marketers must continue to focus on understanding their target audience, identifying what resonates with them, and creating content that encourages engagement.

By aligning campaigns with user preferences and needs, marketers can maintain visibility and control, ensuring their strategies remain effective even as the technological landscape shifts. This blend of data-driven testing and a deep understanding of user behavior will be essential for navigating the evolving advertising ecosystem.

Section 3

Durable Measurement Approaches

Brooke Osmundson Director of Growth Marketing, Smith Micro Software, Inc.

For years, advertisers have been told to prepare for a cookieless future. Many poured time and money into alternative solutions, only to watch Google delay deprecation again and again. Now, with Google officially canceling its plan to phase out third-party cookies in Chrome, that doesn't mean measurement is suddenly stable again.

Privacy regulations, walled gardens, and shifting platform rules continue to erode visibility. Durable measurement now means building systems that don't collapse when policies change.

First-party data, consented tracking, and server-side setups are table stakes. Modeled conversions and clean rooms can help, but they only work if you know how to use them.

Most importantly, advertisers can't rely solely on platform-reported numbers. Independent validation and a consistent framework for measuring ROI are what keep campaigns accountable.

That's why I asked this year's experts on how they're handling measurement:

> **"With cookie deprecation delays and shifting regulations, what durable measurement approaches should advertisers prioritize in 2026?"**

Navah Hopkins Product Liaison, Microsoft

No matter what vertical your brand is in, the most important source of truth is your revenue. Maintaining a consistent view there is really critical.

Additionally, leaning into impression-oriented activities (like impression-based remarketing on Microsoft) will allow you to build audiences regardless of whether a user clicks on your ad.

This means you're also future-proofing yourself against websites going away.

Gil Gildner Agency Co-Founder, Discosloth

Measuring attribution and performance has always been a bit of a deal with the devil for digital advertisers. Digital advertising became so huge, 10-20 years ago, because for the first time in history, we were able to attribute every single dollar of ad spend to specific ads, campaigns, and conversions. This was great for us at the time, because it was huge leverage over existing traditional advertising.

But, I think as an industry, it was a huge mistake to focus so much on attribution. It can't be the only thing that digital does better, because once it's gone, what are we left with? You've got to make sure your marketing and advertising strategy holds up, even if every little last iota of attribution goes away.

That's why I'm pretty skeptical of most Marketing Mix Modeling (MMM) tools or the hyper-attribution tools that are out there: Are we paying thousands per month just to support a flawed advertising strategy?

But in general, in everything we do at Discosloth, we still have pretty good control over attribution, especially from an ecommerce perspective. I recommend building your own internal performance dashboards for clients – pulling in data from Google Ads, Shopify, Analytics, the whole stack – and using those as baselines for the future.

Get better at using external AI tools to analyze your customer datasets and extract whatever performance trends better inform your holistic ad strategy. We have even built custom LLMs with instructions oriented towards this work. It's not hard, it just takes some effort and patience.

Jyll Saskin Gales **Google Ads Coach, Inside Google Ads**

My answer to this question in 2026 is the same as it was in 2019: first-party data.

If you are not yet collecting personally identifiable information (with user consent), and sharing that with your ad platform (with user consent), you will not survive. This is especially true if your business uses a lead generation model.

If the influx of AI tools is the new oil rush, first-party data is the new oil. It's the best possible training material for your bidding, targeting, and creative algorithms to drive the best possible results for your business. And, your own customer data is your biggest competitive advantage!

Jonathan Kagan **Director of Search & Media Strategy, Amsive**

Cookie deprecation has been delayed time and time again. I'm skeptical to what extent it'll ever fully happen in the U.S. market.

But the reality is, for some advertising verticals, especially those with short conversion windows (two or fewer days), the actual potential impact that would've been felt would be quite negligible from a last click standpoint (which is still the frequent point of measurement for most advertisers), so I somewhat deprioritize that as a concern in my planning.

The shifting regulations are very much a different story. From government rule changes to tariffs, it throws a bit of a monkey wrench into how we measure most of our efforts. The concept of cost-per-acquisition (CPA)/cost-per-lead (CPL), conversion rate (CVR), and ROAS can't be done year-over-year as an "apples to apples" concept, without a tweak or calibration to it.

For example, if you were forced to increase prices due to tariffs, and you went from No. 1 most affordable to No. 2 in your competitive set, then you must account for that adjustment when you look to do measurement ultimately.

Mike Ryan **Head of Ecommerce Insights, Smarter Ecommerce**

To me, the core reality of measurement is that it was never as perfect as imagined, but we're now WAY more aware of these imperfections. That's painful but healthy.

We're so often caught between tunnel vision, for example, in-platform metrics like ROAS that are siloed and over-attributed – or zoomed-out views like Marketing Efficiency Ratio that are hard to take action on. Add in Analytics, and some magic pixel tool, and MMM, and server-side tagging, and your backend numbers, and whatever custom thing in Floodlight, and anything else you've got going on.

The most durable thing we can do is focus on the basics. Products we can actually sell. A website that doesn't suck. An offer that gives people instant clarity.

When we talk about measurement, there is no single source of truth. Think of these things as lenses. Choose a couple lenses, not a dozen. Where do you need a microscope, and which source helps? Where do you need satellite intel, and which source helps? And maybe MMM can help you figure out your prescription.

Danielle Wood **Manager, Content & Copy, CallRail**

With cookie deprecation delays and shifting regulations, advertisers in 2026 should prioritize durable measurement approaches centered on first-party and zero-party data. Google's decision to delay third-party cookie deprecation offers businesses a valuable opportunity to adapt their marketing data strategies to focus on direct customer interactions.

It's crucial to continue prioritizing data collection and use tools that gather first-party data. CallRail, for instance, helps businesses collect, analyze, and generate insights from zero and first-party data, providing a solid foundation for future marketing strategies.

Multi-touch attribution data becomes essential to understand the full customer journey, as traditional methods often silo information from different channels.

As Ryan Johnson, Chief Product Officer at CallRail, states, “First-party cookies will work by default in all browsers. If you’re using CallRail for tracking, it’s considered first-party, and it will continue to work even if third-party cookies are ever deprecated in Chrome.” This highlights the importance of using tools that are inherently first-party compliant.

By leveraging Call Tracking and Form Tracking, advertisers gain deep insights into each lead and the performance of their marketing campaigns and ads. This data allows for the creation of campaigns and ads based on insights from real customers, ensuring effectiveness regardless of industry changes. The shift to a marketing strategy built around first and zero-party data is a proactive measure that will create a strong, future-proof infrastructure.

Cookie deprecation feels inevitable at this point, so why worry when it finally happens? Be the business that already has a backup plan and winning strategy in place when your competition doesn’t.

Section 4

Generative AI And Creative Workflows

Brooke Osmundson Director of Growth Marketing, Smith Micro Software, Inc.

Finally, I asked contributors to weigh in on what I see as one of the most important shifts in PPC: How generative AI is changing the way we talk to customers.

Creative has always been the heartbeat of a campaign, and now platforms are eager to fill ads with automatically generated headlines, descriptions, and images. External tools promise the same, offering endless variations at scale. The speed and volume are impressive, but that's not what most practitioners are concerned about.

Across the responses, a clear theme emerged: Many worry about brand voice, trust, and authenticity being diluted when AI steps in. Generic copy doesn't resonate with customers. Images that look slightly "off" can undermine confidence in a brand. And the more marketers hand over creative to automation, the harder it becomes to ensure originality.

That doesn't mean AI-generated creative has no role. Some advertisers find value in using it as a starting point or for quick testing. But the consensus is that marketers need guardrails. Human oversight, brand guidelines, and structured testing are what keep AI outputs from drifting into territory that feels inauthentic or unreliable.

The final prompt I asked contributors to respond to was:

> **How is generative AI changing the way you approach ad copy and creative testing? Do you trust platform-generated assets, or do you prefer external workflows? How can readers adapt an AI-first creative strategy?**

Navah Hopkins Product Liaison, Microsoft

Humans need to be involved at every level of account management (including creative).

However, ad platform creatives can be great if the right prompts are present. Make sure to answer all relevant questions with your prompt. The creative output will only be as good as the inputs you give AI.

I trust autogenerated assets to be a reasonable estimation of how ad platforms understand your site/business. If you don't like the autogenerated assets, that's a sign that your website/way you're describing your business isn't clear, and could be an opportunity to refine organic content in partnership with running paid campaigns.

That said, auto-generated content often performs just as well, if not better than human-generated creative. The key difference is that the auto-generated creative won't outperform a marketer who invests serious effort in their creative for each stage of the funnel.

Working in partnership is often the way to get the best outcomes, though autogenerated creative can be a powerful test.

Gil Gildner Agency Co-Founder, Discosloth

We don't really depend upon platform-generated assets, as most of our clients either have a robust internal creative department, or prefer custom messaging that's hard to generate from the platform-generated tools.

We do use external AI workflows and copy them into campaigns, but it always requires editing and tweaking before it's perfect. One of the huge benefits of AI is just the "ideation" phase: Tools can come up with variations that would be almost impossible to brainstorm. It's like having a few junior copywriters on staff at your beck and call.

There's still a lot of room for improvement for visual generation, although Google's Product Studio is getting better for ecommerce product shots. I wouldn't necessarily recommend adopting an AI-first creative strategy just to do it, only if it results in a better bottom line for both your agency and your clients.

The reality is, though, we are technical marketers working in a rapidly changing market. It moves fast. Our job is to stay in front of the change.

If you aren't flexible and willing to experiment with new technologies, you'll likely be left behind as the early adopters will be better poised to service the new generation of advertisers.

Jyll Saskin Gales Google Ads Coach, Inside Google Ads

I don't find Google's built-in AI-created ad copy or ad creatives to be helpful yet, because they are often quite irrelevant to the realities of my clients' businesses. However, I think that will change in 2026.

New features like text guidelines for automatically created assets, and Gemini-powered image editing capabilities, will help make AI-first creative more relevant, providing the much-needed context that's been missing from the AI equation.

I recommend that all advertisers continue to test these new features, as they are constantly getting better and feel very close to finally being ready for prime time.

Jonathan Kagan Director of Search & Media Strategy, Amsive

So far, generative AI really is not changing the way we approach ad copy and creative all that much. It's assisting us periodically in the thought-starter process, or helping us when we get some degree of writer's block, but isn't changing our concept of themes or how to write and develop it.

We look at it mostly as a support function, but not as a final say or deciding function.

Testing platform-generated assets, specifically creative, has been a bit difficult. Often, we don't let AI create an entire ad, but parts of it, so weeding out the success or failure of that specific part becomes a bit more difficult to do and analyze.

Based on experience of what has been developed, as well as client brand standards, we have not been able or comfortable enough to allow a completely AI-generated creative to go into market for measurement. This is primarily due to the client's legal guidelines, brand guidelines, or the creative itself is just ultimately low quality.

Needless to say, it is definitely a work in progress. That doesn't mean there isn't a place for it. I recommend using it as a thought-starter, or find a mid/low volume effort, with more flexibility on its guidelines, to give it a proper test.

Mike Ryan Head of Ecommerce Insights, Smarter Ecommerce

Read an eye-tracking study showing how consumers look at ads, and be humbled. While generative AI technology is not perfectly ready yet, I feel confident that it will be, and it makes a lot of sense to start using AI for these tasks.

Producing ad copy & creative is like throwing seeds to the wind: they need to exist at a massive scale, with lots of variation. Some precious few will take root.

Currently, there are other areas that benefit more from human effort, like landing pages and product detail pages, titles and descriptions, higher-value brand ads, and more. The best way into this is to simply start. Compare the performance of human-led copy and creative vs AI-led, and then compare the costs.

And remember that it doesn't have to be an either/or decision, AI assets don't need to be a replacement: They can also be supplemental.

Danielle Wood Manager, Content & Copy, CallRail

Generative AI is redefining our work, moving the marketer's role from primary drafter to strategic editor. AI functions as a digital scratch pad, speeding up the entire brainstorming process. You can instantly generate a high volume of diverse hooks, tones, and value propositions to test against each other. Capacity for quick variation testing leads to significantly faster optimization and greater campaign efficiency across all digital channels.

The critical decision point is trust. While platform automation is great for testing volume, its outputs often lack that essential spark, the necessary brand precision, and emotional nuance. A blended approach is key. Use automation to run your tests at scale, but always maintain human oversight to ensure your final copy and creative choices align with your brand voice and strategic goals.

To build an AI-first creative strategy, your team needs to adapt its mindset. First, view AI as a creative partner: use it for ideation and variation, not final copy. Second, train the AI using your specific brand voice and high-performing historical data for more relevant outputs. Finally, build clear feedback loops between AI-generated tests and your actual performance metrics to continually refine its utility. The goal is simple: maximize scale without sacrificing brand authenticity.

Do You Have Predictions To Share?

The experts featured here have offered practical, unfiltered perspectives on some of the biggest shifts shaping PPC right now. From the realities of AI-driven campaigns to the challenges of durable measurement, their insights reflect what practitioners are actually experiencing day to day.

I was honored to be given the reins to moderate and author this year's PPC Trends ebook. Pulling this together gave me a chance to step back and reflect on how quickly our industry is changing, and I hope you find as much value in these perspectives as I did. My goal was to frame these conversations in a way that not only highlights emerging trends but also sparks meaningful discussions within your own teams and with your clients.

If you have your own predictions for where PPC is headed, we'd love for you to join the conversation. Share your thoughts with SEJ on your favorite social media platform and keep the discussion going.

LinkedIn **X** **Facebook**

Thank you for reading this year's PPC Trends. While the tools and tactics will continue to evolve, one thing won't change: PPC has always been about more than platforms. It's about the people using them, testing ideas, and pushing strategies forward.

That's what makes this community so powerful and why hearing from so many voices in one place is such a privilege!

CallRail is the lead engagement platform that makes it easy for businesses to attract more leads, convert more customers, and optimize their marketing. Serving more than 220,000 businesses worldwide, CallRail's AI-powered solutions help businesses attribute each call, text, chat, and form to their marketing journey, use insights from their conversations to better understand their buyers, and eliminate missed opportunities with AI that can handle lead interactions 24/7.

CallRail has grown from the G2 top-rated inbound call tracking solution to include Form Tracking, Conversation Intelligence®, Premium Conversation IntelligenceTM, Convert Assist, and Voice Assist. CallRail's award-winning platform integrates with dozens of leading marketing and sales software, and offers affiliate, agency, and technology partnership opportunities, helping businesses earn, grow, and build with CallRail. For more information, visit www.callrail.com.

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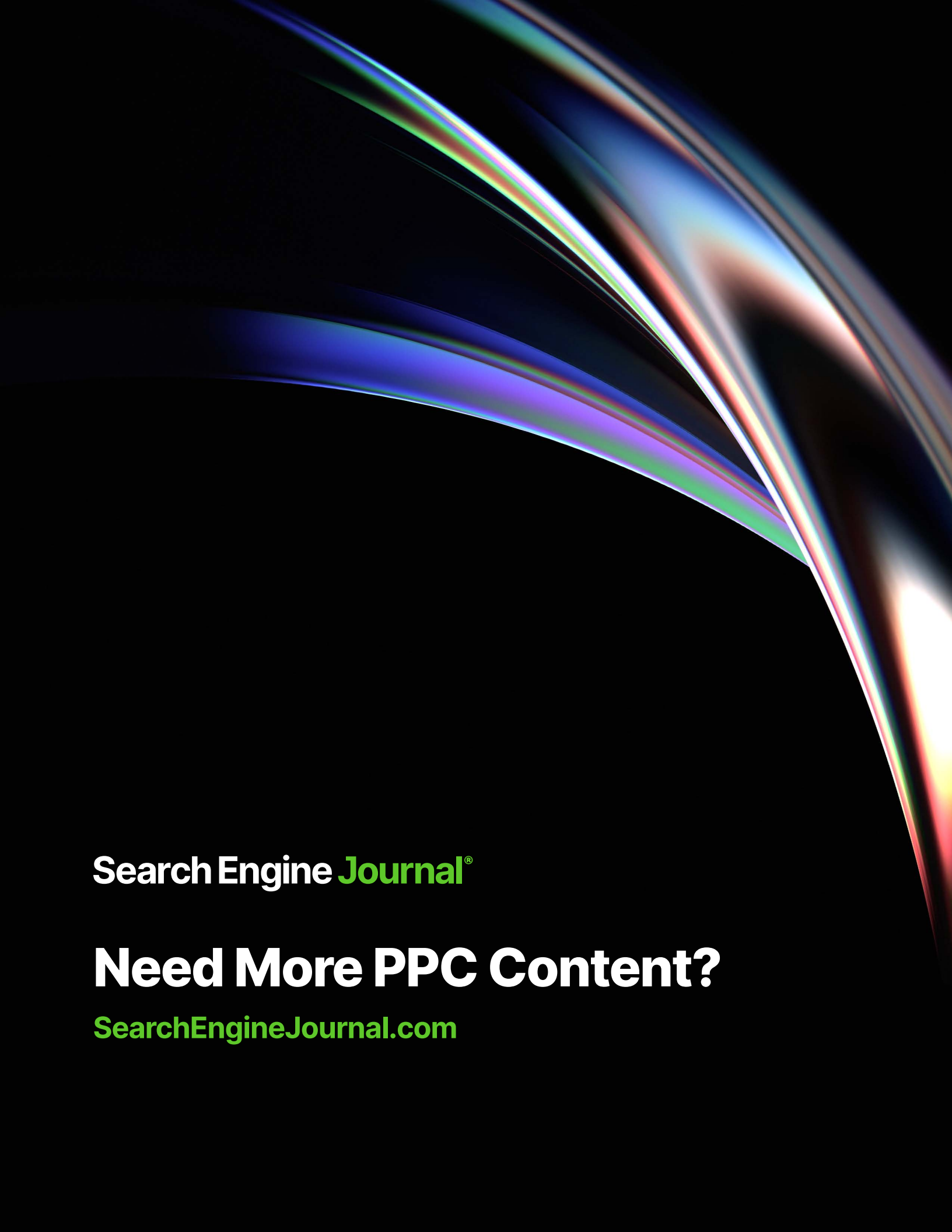
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